

CORE FORMULA

Acknowledge the friction: "I hear that the current version doesn't work." -> **Ask for workable conditions:** "What would make it workable?" -> **Protect autonomy:** "And if it's not workable at all, that's useful to know too." -> **Agree the next small step:** "Let's use that as the constraint and adjust from there."

MINIMUM VIABLE MOVE

Validate the friction, then ask one question: "Got it. What would make this workable, if anything?" — and stay quiet while they think.

BEST FOR

- Someone is hesitant, vague, overloaded, or objecting but still engaged.
- A plan is blocked by logistics, risk, timing, scope, fairness, confidence, or missing context.
- You need to know what would make a request feasible without guessing.
- A negotiation needs mutual conditions, not positional argument.
- You are genuinely willing to change your plan if the conditions are reasonable.

PHRASE BANK

Quick openers · Starter one-liners

- "What would make this workable, if anything?"
- "Got it. What would make this work for you?"
- "What would need to change for this to work?"
- "What's the one thing that would make this easier?"
- "Is there a version of this that works?"
- "What would help here?"
- "What would make this doable?"
- "So what would this need to look like to work?"

Warm & validating · Acknowledge before you ask

- "I hear that this version doesn't work. What would?"
- "That makes sense. What would make it feel realistic?"
- "I get why that's hard. What would need to change?"
- "Fair concern. What would make a next step feel okay?"
- "I don't want to make this harder than it needs to be. What would help?"
- "You know your side of this better than I do. What would make it workable?"
- "That's a fair worry. What would need to be true for this to work?"

Work & planning · Workload, deadlines, projects

- "What would need to change for this to be realistic on your side?"
- "What would need to change for this to work with your current workload?"
- "What constraints would we need to solve before this becomes workable?"
- "What condition would make this option worth testing?"
- "What would need to be true for this to work on your end?"
- "Is there a scope that would make this workable, or is the plan itself the problem?"
- "What would make this realistic with the time we've actually got?"

Clarify & narrow · When the resistance is vague

- "Which part is least workable: timing, scope, risk, or something else?"
- "Is it the timing, or is it something bigger?"
- "What's the main obstacle here?"
- "If one thing changed, what would it be?"
- "Is there one constraint that matters most?"
- "Is this a "not like this," or a "not at all"?"

Boundary & autonomy · Make "no" a real option

- "If the answer is no, I'll respect that. Is there any version that would work?"
- "No pressure to solve it now. What would need to be true for this to work?"
- "I'll take a no. Is there a version that would feel okay, or should we drop it?"
- "You don't have to make this work — I just want to understand what would."
- "If there's no workable version, that's useful to know too."
- "Given what happened, what would make a reset workable from here?"

Under pressure · High stakes, slow the tempo

- "Before we force a decision, what would make this practical enough to consider?"
- "I hear the concern. What would make a next step feel fair and workable?"
- "Let's not lock this in yet. What would need to change first?"
- "What would make this safe enough to try?"
- "I'd rather get this right than rushed. What would make it workable?"

After they answer · Responding to a condition or a no

- "That's useful. Let me see if I can work within that."
- "Those are concrete. I can commit to some of them and I'll be honest about the rest."
- "Thanks for being clear. I won't push this version."
- "That helps. Let me check whether that works on my side."
- "If I can't meet that, I won't pretend the plan still works."

WEAK -> BETTER -> BEST

- Weak: "Why not?"
Better: "What's the main obstacle?"
Best: "I hear this version isn't easy. What would make it workable, if anything?"
- Weak: "What do you want from me then?"
Better: "What would help?"
Best: "What would need to change for this to feel realistic and fair on your side?"
- Weak: "Can you just make it work?"
Better: "Could a smaller version work?"
Best: "Is there a smaller or different version that would work, or is this a no?"
- Weak: "So what's your counteroffer?"
Better: "What would work for you?"
Best: "No pressure to solve it instantly. What would make the next step workable from your side?"

DECISION TREE

If They're emotionally activated

Validate first; don't ask for conditions yet.

"I may be moving too fast. Let me understand the concern first."

If Their resistance is vague

Ask which part is least workable to narrow it down.

"Which part is least workable: timing, scope, risk, or something else?"

If They name a specific condition

Reflect it back, decide whether it can be met, and confirm.

"So if that changed, this could work. Let me check I can do it."

If They give several conditions

Ask which one matters most rather than solving everything at once.

"Which of those matters most to get right?"

If The condition is impossible

Say so cleanly and ask whether another version exists.

"I can't do that one. Is there another version that would work?"

If They say no version works

Accept the no and stop negotiating.

"Thanks for being clear. I won't push this."

If You feel pressure creeping into your own tone

Use a recovery phrase and release autonomy.

"I may be pushing too hard. I'll step back."

SCENARIOS

Workload conflict

Acknowledge their capacity and ask for realistic conditions. — ""What would need to change for this to be realistic with your current workload?""

Scheduling friction

Separate the commitment from the timing. — ""Is there a time frame that would make this workable, or is the plan not workable?""

Boundary conversation

Respect the boundary first, then ask lightly. — ""I'll respect a no. Is there any version that would feel okay, or should we drop it?""

Team disagreement

Move from defended positions to shared constraints. — ""What condition would make this option acceptable enough to test?""

Family logistics

Make the invisible burden visible before deciding. — ""What would make the weekend plan manageable instead of stressful?""

Repair after a miss

Ask for the conditions that would rebuild trust. — ""Given what happened, what would make a reset workable from here?""

WHEN NOT TO USE

- The person has given a clear final no or asked to stop discussing it.
- Safety, legal, consent, privacy, or ethical boundaries are at stake.
- You hold power over the person and the question could land as pressure.
- They are emotionally flooded and need validation, time, or repair first.
- You are not actually willing to adapt and only want them to concede.

7-DAY PRACTICE DRILL

Day 1 — Spot the resistance

Pick a recent moment someone pushed back on you. Write the hesitation in their own words — the actual sentence they said, or the delay you noticed.

Day 2 — Write the validation

Draft one sentence that names the friction without arguing with it, e.g. "That makes sense, last time it ran over."

Day 3 — Draft the question

Write one short workability question with an autonomy release built in, using "if anything" or "or is this a no?"

Day 4 — Rehearse the silence

Say your question aloud, then stay quiet for a slow three seconds. Notice the urge to rescue the pause with a suggestion — and don't.

Day 5 — Sort the answers

Write five possible replies and label each: workable condition, hard boundary, missing information, emotional concern, or final no.

Day 6 — Respond without defending

Practise replying to one workable condition and one flat no. Adapt the plan for the first; accept the second cleanly, no argument.

Day 7 — Run it live

Use the move once in a real professional, social, or family situation. Afterwards score it: Did I validate? Ask one clear question? Allow no? Avoid defending?

AFTER-ACTION CHECKLIST

- Did I treat resistance as information, not disobedience?
- Did I validate before asking for workability when emotion was high?
- Was my question short enough to answer?
- Did I add "if anything" or another autonomy release when it mattered?
- Did I accept a clear no without arguing?
- Did I act on the condition they named, or did I quietly ignore it?